

Alaska-wide Sablefish Stock Assessment Review Performance of Work Statement

National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA)
National Marine Fisheries Service (NMFS)
Center for Independent Experts (CIE) Program
External Independent Peer Review

Terms of Reference for the Peer Review

CIE reviewers are contracted to complete their independent peer review based on the Terms of Reference (ToRs). Therefore, the CIE-NMFS review and approval process is based on whether the CIE independent reports addressed each of the ToRs. The AFSC requests an in-person CIE review from June 16-18, 2026 in Juneau, AK for the Alaska-wide sablefish stock assessment. CIE reviewers shall address the following ToRs during the peer review and in the CIE report. The responsibilities of the CIE reviewers are to:

- 1) Become familiar with the stock assessment documents, data inputs, and analytical models along with other pertinent information prior to the review panel meeting (document list to be disseminated). Review and evaluate the proposed Alaska-wide sablefish stock assessment models, including data inputs and analytical approaches, to determine whether they are suitable for estimating current stock status, projecting future abundance, and determining Overfishing Levels (OFLs) and Acceptable Biological Catches (ABCs). Provide recommendations on which model provides the most suitable basis for operational management advice:
 - a) *Model 26.1_Pan_2_Flts*;
 - b) *Model 26.2_FAA*.
- 2) Provide feedback on whether a fleets-as-areas (FAA; *Model 26.2_FAA*) model should be used for sablefish operational management.
 - a) What are the tradeoffs in using the FAA model for dealing with ontogenetic movement patterns and recent survey design changes compared to the current single region panmictic assessment?
 - i) Provide recommendations on the most appropriate parametrization of fleet structure (number of fleets per fishery/survey, as a proxy for regions) and selectivity (asymptotic vs. domed, to address availability by region) in the FAA model.
 - b) Do the results of the 3 (*Model 26.3_3_Reg_Spatial*) or 5 (*Model 26.4_5_Reg_Spatial*) region spatially explicit models that estimate movement and integrate tagging data provide any further insight for parametrizing a single region assessment?
 - i) Provide advice on the primary limitations/uncertainties for using a spatial model as the basis of sablefish management in the future?
- 3) Highlight potential strengths and weaknesses of the existing and proposed assessment frameworks, including model assumptions, estimates, fits to data (survey indices and age compositions along with fishery catch-at-age data), model diagnostics, and major sources of uncertainty.
 - a) Provide feedback on whether further model complexity (i.e., time-varying selectivity and/or growth) is warranted given model complexity/parsimony/sample size tradeoffs, particularly in the context of a highly parametrized sex-specific FAA model (if recommended). Are time-block approaches sufficient to address potentially time-varying processes?